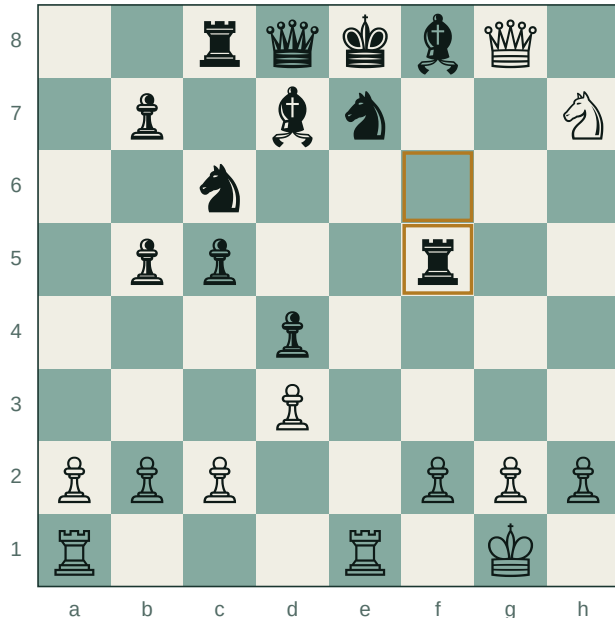


Smothered mates: White, move 18

Smothered mates

White to move



Previous move: 17...Rf5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Qg6+ Rf7 19. Nf6#

18.Qg6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From g6 it attacks king on e8, rook on f5 and knight on c6.
Recorded reply: **18...Rf7**.

19.Nf6# Mate: knight on f6 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on e8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f6. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on e8. Absolute pin: bishop on f8 and knight on e7.